

But Now What: Can We Still Use Twitter Data For Researching Political Candidates?

Changes in Twitter/X Usage in European Parliament Election Campaigns

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September 17, 2026

Background - Twitter and Politics Research

- Before 2022 the **main social media platform used by politicians**
- Quickly came to **dominate computational political social media research** (Pfeffer et al. 2023)
- Longstanding concerns on **representativeness of the platform** to measure public opinion and attitudes (Barberá & Rivero 2015, Diaz et al. 2016, Mellon & Prosser 2017, Stier et al. 2020)
- **Algorithmic amplification of (center-)right content** and **far-right associated bots** already skewed the platform rightward

Background - 2022 Change in Ownership

- Loosening of moderation, increase vitriol and decrease quality of information ([Hickey et al. 2023](#), [Corsi 2024](#), [Hickey et al. 2025](#), [Koo et al. 2025](#), [McCabe et al. 2024](#))
- Algorithmic changes, favoring “news influencers” ([Özturan et al. 2025](#))
- Loss in (ad) revenue, decrease in usage (23% fewer daily users in US), journalists leaving the platform



Background - Change in the incentive structure

Fundamental change in incentives for remaining on the platform

- **Shrinking audience** $\rightsquigarrow$ less useful as a broadcasting platform $\rightsquigarrow$ ↓ appeal
- **Less moderation** $\rightsquigarrow$ ↑ changes of vitriol and abuse, decrease quality of information $\rightsquigarrow$ reputational risk

Mixed research on parties' response:

- Still most used platform by politicians (Jan & Sattelmayer 2025)
- ↓ in RT of politician content, but ↑ in likes (Nutakki et al. 2025)
- Recent coordinated exit by German SPD, Greens & Left signals a fundamental shift in incentives

Background – European Parliament Elections

- Comparison of candidates and parties with **varying levels of popularity**
- **Similar context** across a **wide range of countries** (concurrent elections, same campaign period)
- Can **track repeat candidates** over time
- **Expand beyond US** focused research
- 2014/2019/2024 captures **rise, peak, and decline of Twitter** usage

Research Questions

1. **Is X is still a relevant arena for politicians across the EU?**
2. **Who is present on the platform, how often do they use it, and what content is discussed?**

Comparison: 2019 (anchor) vs 2024/2014 EP election candidates

Expectations

- H1 **The proportion of candidates with an account, and their usage of the platform, decreased between 2019 and 2024**
- H2 **This decrease is even more pronounced for non-far-right politicians**
- H3 **Issues associated with the far right (crime & immigration) increased in prevalence on the platform**
- RQ1 **Did engagement with content generated by far-right accounts increase?**

Data & methods

European Parliament Elections 2014, 2019, 2024

Candidate Data

- All candidates of parties polling above 3% in EP elections
- Around 6,000 candidates per election (Nulty et al. 2016, Stier et al. 2020)

Twitter Data

- All Tweets and metadata for the last 4 weeks of the campaign
- Around 300,000 Tweets per campaign

Issue Classification - Approach

- Change in issues discussed, level of engagement
- ~100,000 manually labeled Tweets (2019), 9 languages, 17 coders
- Classify remaining 2019 Tweets, and all 2024 (and 2014)
- **Political issues:** Economy, environment, EU, immigration, crime, democracy, other issues (open)

Issue Classification - Method

- **Multilingual sentence embeddings**
paraphrase-multilingual-MiniLM-L12-v2 transformer model
(Reimers & Gurevych 2019)
- **Supervised classification** (glmnet) ridge, lasso, and elastic-net regression
- Leave-one-country-out (**LOCO**) **cross-validation**

Table: Classification Performance (full sample)

Task	Best model	Acc.	Prec.	Rec.	F1
Political content	lasso	.90	.93	.96	.94
Political issue	elastic-net	.75	.73	.81	.76
Economy	elastic-net	.85	.65	.76	.69
Green issue	lasso	.93	.77	.82	.79
Immigration	lasso	.97	.69	.62	.65
Crime	ridge	.89	.58	.62	.60
Pro democracy	elastic-net	.85	.38	.56	.44
EU	ridge	.85	.57	.75	.65
Pro-EU	elastic-net	.71	.65	.77	.70

Country-agnostic performance for political content; weaker, higher cross-country variance for immigration & crime. Reduced reliability and classifier performance for democracy related content

Data & Methods

Two analysis stages:

1. **Between-candidates** 2019 vs. 2024
2. **Within-candidates** returning candidates

Data & Methods

- All 2019 and 2024 candidates (UK removed)
- 635 repeat candidates with Twitter account (536 active) 2019, 2024
- Multi-level logit (adoption), linear models (usage/engagement logged)
- Random intercepts for party and country fixed effects
- **Outcomes:**
 - 1) Has account, 2) total number of posts, 3) total engagement (robust if we use median likes/retweets)
- **Predictors:**
 - Election year, party type (far right dummy), gender (dummy), party national vote share, follower count (logged)
- Additive models, follower by separate models with party $\times$ year interactions

Descriptive Summary

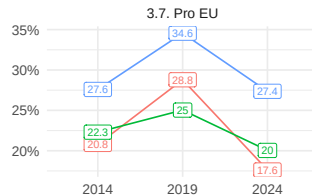
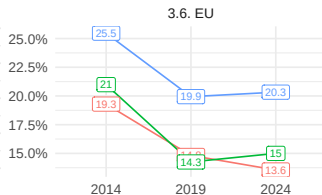
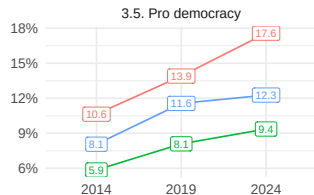
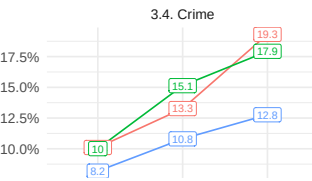
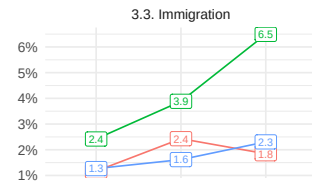
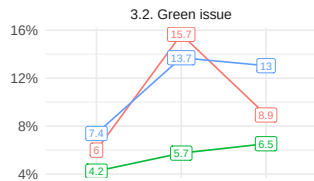
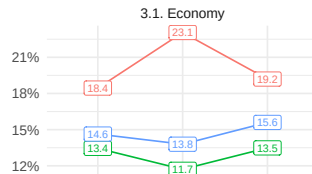
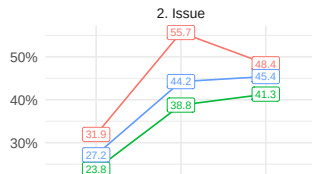
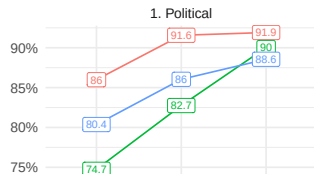
Table: Twitter/X Adoption

Group	Adoption Rate			Net Change	
	2014	2019	2024	14-19	19-24
All	37.9%	51.8%	47.4%	+13.9	-4.4
Far right	26.9%	51.4%	49.7%	+24.5	-1.7
Other	40.2%	51.9%	46.8%	+11.7	-5.1

Table: Twitter/X Usage

Group	Avg Tweets/Candidate			Net Change	
	2014	2019	2024	14-19	19-24
All	117	114	90.5	-3.30	-23.4
Far right	114	137	150	+23.2	+13.5
Other	118	109	72.3	-8.6	-36.9

Total tweets per party divided by number of candidates with Twitter account



-a- Far left -a- Far right -a- Other

Between-Candidate Analysis

Figure: Predicted Usage and Engagement by Year - Party Type

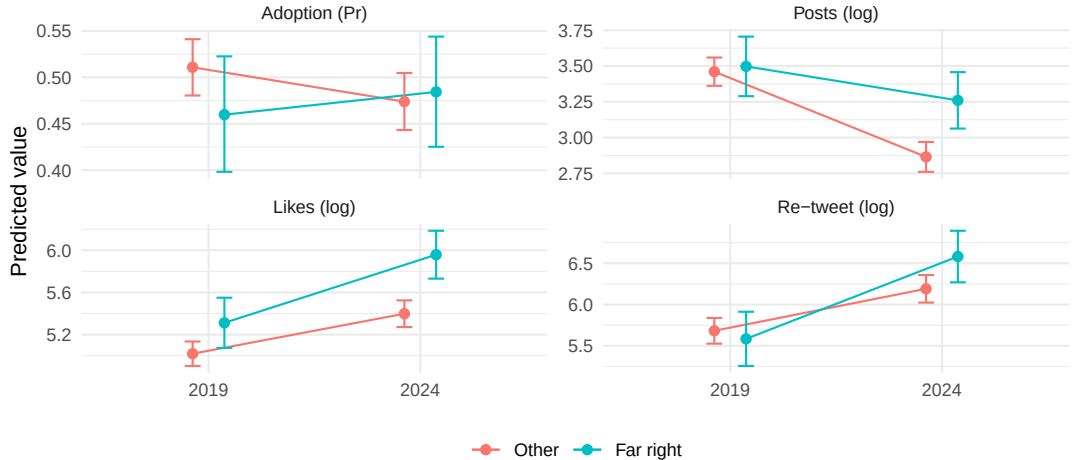
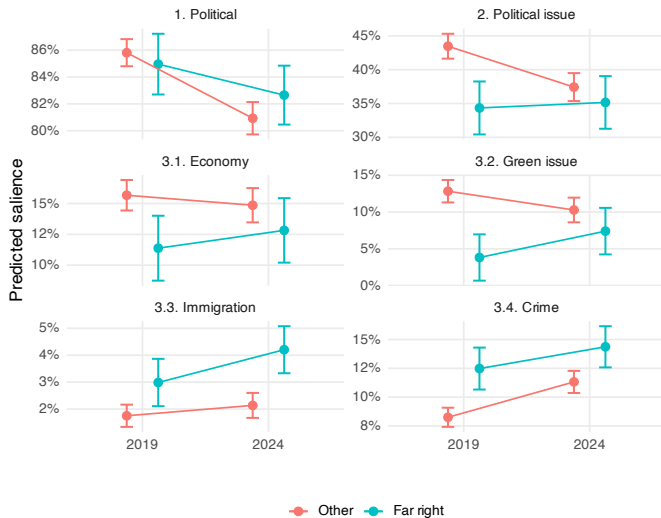


Figure: Predicted Content by Year - Party Type

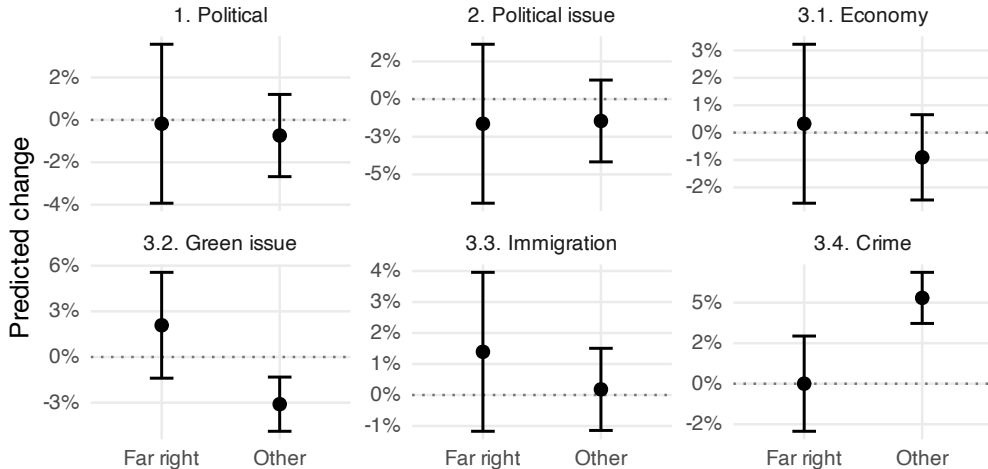


Within-Candidate Analysis

Table: Change in activity and engagement among returning candidates (2024–2019).

	Δ Posts	Δ Likes	Δ Retweets
Far-right	148.496*** (28.019)	22309.190* (10285.681)	38464.388*** (10097.239)
Intercept	12.808 (68.351)	8895.943 (24014.497)	2930.677 (23436.666)

Figure: Predicted Content by Year - Party Type



Summary – Hypotheses & Research Question

- **H1 – Partly supported:** fewer accounts & posts, *but* engagement rose
- **H2 – Supported:** drop weaker for the far right; non-far-right retreat
- **H3 – Supported:** both far-right associated issues are more salient
economy and environment content decreased (driven by mainstream parties)
- **RQ1 – Yes:** up for all, far more for the far right $\Rightarrow$ the assumed demand-collapse mechanism is *not* supported
- **Within (returning candidates) – behavioral, not compositional:** same divergence among repeat candidates (far right post more, others fewer); those who stayed are more similar to each other (almost independent of party affiliation); the far-right immigration rise is driven by *new entrants*;

Bottom line: X is still usable for candidate research, but a smaller, far-right-skewed arena – what you can learn depends on what you measure and who stayed.

Project Next Steps

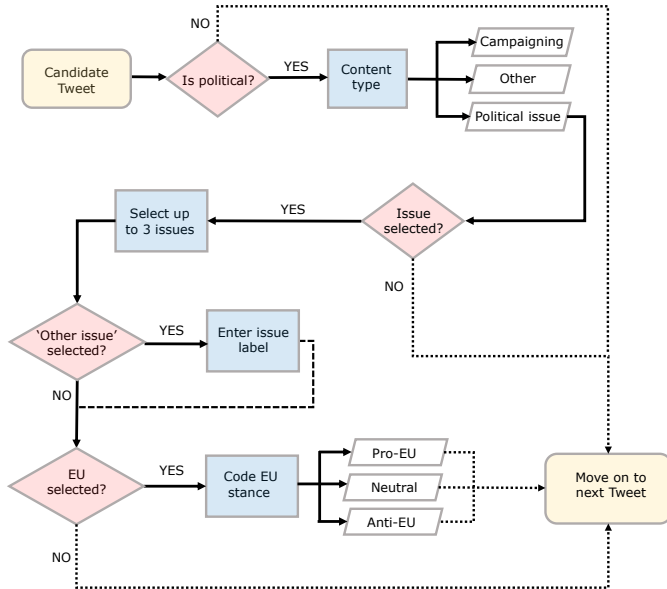
- Incorporate 2014 candidate data into analysis (as baseline, pre-anchor)
- Include party/party leader accounts
- Include control for issue salience: CMP and/or party accounts
- Include additional issue: EU salience and position, and liberal democracy
- Add a layer of LLM/AI coding to check/validate out-of-sample (years and countries) predictions

Issue Classification

Table: Tweet language distribution and sampling

Country	Language	All Candidate Tweets	Sampled Candidate Tweets
UK	English	131,332	13,500
France	French	62,403	13,500
Spain	Spanish	52,824	13,500
Poland	Polish	43,770	13,500
Ireland*	English	14,697	14,697
Netherlands	Dutch	13,793	7,500
Germany*	German	13,156	13,156
Greece*	Greek	4,349	4,349
Hungary*	Hungarian	326	326

*All candidate tweets were manually coded for these countries



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